Song and Dance

By Alan Shapiro

Everything the Traffic Will Allow

The two boys don't suspect
they don't exist.
And Ethel Merman is
the shade of a shade –
what Plato says
all poetry is –
a record
spinning beneath
a needle
as the boys
lip-sync into
imaginary mikes
her glottal swagger,
brassy, large,
streetwise
and from their mouths
so touchingly naïve
for being so . . .
There's no
people
like show
people . . . .
Their parents clap
and whistle

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from the bed,
propped up
on pillows . . .
Everything about
it is appealing . . .
They are shouting "Encore!
Bravo!"
when the boys,
like chorus girls,
arms on each other's shoulders,
step-kid their way
across the room
and out of it,
then back . . .
stealing that extra bow . . . .
Shades of a shade.
What poetry is.
Because there's nowhere else
for them to be
except
inside the room
in which it isn't
when it is,
in which
there is no room
uUnless I think of it –
the boys
their arms flung wide
on one knee
mouthing the last words
before the needle slides

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off into silence,
the parents propped up
on pillows,
half laughing, half
shouting "Bravo!
Encore!"
All now
just the shade
of a shade –
like no
people
I know . . .

INTRODUCTION

Ranging through memories old and recent, factual and imagined, Alan Shapiro celebrates his brother, David, a song-and-dance man diagnosed with inoperable brain cancer. All poems are from Shapiro's collection Song and Dance . . . The opening poem portrays the brothers as children, lip-synching and step-kicking to an Ethel Merman record for their parents. Everything the Traffic will allow by Alan Shapiro. In the next selection "Sleet" both his father and mother are remembered.

Sleet

What was it like before the doctor got there?

Till then, we were in the back seat of the warm

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dark bubble of the old Buick. We were where
we'd never not been, no matter where we were.

And when the doctor got there?

Everything outside was in a rage of wind and sleet,
we were children, brothers, safe in the back seat,
for once not fighting, just listening, watching the storm.

Weren't you afraid that something bad might happen?

Our father held the wheel with just two fingers
even though the car skidded and fishtailed
and the chains clanged raggedly over ice and asphalt.

Weren't you afraid at all?

Dad sang for someone to fly him to the moon,
to let him play among the stars, while Mom
held up the lighter to another Marlboro.

But when the doctor started speaking. . .

The tip of the Marlboro was a bright red star.
Her lips pursed and she released a ring of Saturn,
which dissolved as we caught at it, as my dad sang Mars.

When you realized what the doctor was saying. . .

They were closer to the storm in the front seat.
The high beams, weak as steam against the walled
swirling,
only illuminated what we couldn't see.

When he described it, the tumor in the brain and what it
meant. . .

See, we were children. Then we weren't. Or my brother
wasn't
He was driving now, he gripped the steering wheel
with both hands and stared hard at the panicked wipers.

What did you feel?

Just sleet, the slick road, the car going way too fast,
no brother beside me in the back seat, no singing father,
no mother, no ring of Saturn to catch at as it floats.

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TRANSITION

The accident that doesn't happen in the childhood memory of "Sleet" happens in "The Accident" which juxtaposes the intense physicality of a hummingbird and the consolations of song with the accident of the poem's title—a nurse dropping a physically fading David in the bathroom.

The Accident

While it was happening,
        the absolute
not me of it, the all
        of a sudden see-
through whir of wings beside me
        that the late sun
just as I looked up
        turned to a hovering
flash, a watery gray—
        green iridescence
as the beak dipped into
        a funnel of blossom,
dipped and was gone, and not even
        the blossom's white
tip bent in its going,
        or shivered—

While this, which could have happened
        without me, here
or elsewhere, happened the way
        it did, and would

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continue happening
for others, for no one,
for nothing but the blind urge
of its happening,
this ever-transient
accidental
crossing of momentums
that was, in this case,
beautiful but could
have not been and so
seemed all the more consoling
for the thought—

even the thought of death,
just then, consoling,
shaping itself inside me
as the now there
now not there hovering
of bird, flower, late
sun iridescences—
beloved singers,
you who in the aftermath
surged from the shadows
to sing in your different voices
the same song, Route
of evanescence, Mother
of beauty, It
avails not, time nor place,
distance avails not,

if you had known, just then,

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three hundred miles
away, in another state,
that one of the nurses
getting my brother up
from the commode
and back to bed, the one
who held him on
his left side, the dead side,
all of a sudden
lost hold of him and, as
he fell hard, grabbed
for the loose papery gown
and ripped it off,
so that he lay there naked,
utterly exposed—

beloved singers, tricksters
of solace, if
you had known this, seen
this, as I did not,
you would have offered him
no sumptuous
destitution, no fire-
fangled feathers,
or blab about death as being
luckier than one
supposes. You would have bowed
your heads, you would
have silently slipped back
into the shadows

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out of which you surged forth,
singing to me.

TRANSITION

Song and Dance is much more than a collection about a brother's death; it is a story of family and memory, a song for a sibling's life. The final selection shares the collection's title Song and Dance by Alan Shapiro

Song and Dance

Did you ever have a family?
Dark
dining room,
bright kitchen,
white steam
from the big pot my mother's stirring
reaching in wavy tendrils to her face,
around her face, all the way around
to me at the table, then beyond me
into the darkness where my brother is.

Were you ever a child?
I'm hungry
but I know we'll
eat soon,
so

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even the hunger's sweet.

Did you ever really have a brother?
He's singing
there in the dark
corner
beside the stereo,
the volume turned down so low
all we hear is him, his voice, and
his eyes are closed so that there's
nothing around him anywhere
that might reveal he isn't
who the song insists he is.

And that is?
Irresistible,
unforgettable,
someone
to whom
as in imaginary gardens
where "the nectarine and curious
peach into my hands themselves
do reach," love comes as soon
as called, comes just as dreamed.

Did any of this ever happen?

The hunger's
sweet,
it's as if
the song weaves
through the fragrance of the braiding
steam from him to me to her
to me to him because her eyes
are closed now too; her
slippered feet tap, caper
a soft shoe while the ladle
sways in her hand as she stirs.

Were you ever a child?
I know
I'll eat soon.
Did you ever really have a brother?
You should have
heard him,
his voice was
unforgettable, irresistible, his voice
was an imaginary garden woven through with
fragrance.

Did you ever have a family?
Their eyes are closed.
That's how I know

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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